Department has recorded a 13 per cent deficit in overall rainfall during the four-month monsoon season, the largest in more than a decade.

STATES UNDER STRESS

The fallout is already evident in large parts of India. The Union government has declared five states—Karnataka, Maharashtra, parts of Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Rajasthan—as drought-hit so far. According to Union agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, 611,000 hectares of cropland have been affected by extreme rains and floods.

Karnataka is the first state to declare 177 of 240 taluks as drought-affected due to the rainfall deficit of over 35 per cent, the worst in 150 years. On September 22, deputy chief minister G. Parameshwara told the assembly that sowing is below 75 per cent in 11 districts and a substantial portion of crops has been lost. The state government has estimated overall economic loss at Rs 40,000 crore, of which crop damage stands at Rs 18,748.2 crore, a staggering 33 per cent, across 1.95 million ha in 101 taluks.

Maharashtra's plight is no better. After two months of healthy rainfall, the monsoon went missing in parts of the state, with crops wilting and water sources running dry. On September 26, the state declared 265 of its 358 talukas—74 per cent—as drought-affected, with extreme conditions in the long-distressed agrarian regions of Marathwada and Vidarbha, as well as pockets of northern and western Maharashtra, including Solapur. While officials are still assessing the crop damage, several farmers have reported severe losses in the state's main cash crops—soybean, maize and cotton. Kharif (June-September season) crop losses of up to 89-90 per cent are likely in some tehsils of Solapur, while soybean production in Buldhana could fall by 70-75 per cent. The production of the famous Indrayani rice, grown in parts of Pune district, will also bear the brunt of the monsoon. On September 29, chief minister Devendra Fadnavis said drought relief measures would be rolled out in the 93 talukas that had been excluded from the first list of drought-hit talukas.

In Telangana, the rainfall deficit has been less pronounced on paper but more uneven on the ground. The state recorded a 17 per cent rain deficit during this kharif season—considered a 'normal monsoon' scientifically. However, farmer organisations such as Rythu Swarajya Vedika say the figure does not reflect the severity of the situation. Several districts and mandals recorded much higher deficits, ranging from 20 to 59 per cent, including Mahbubnagar and Nalgonda in south Telangana, causing crops to wither or dry out in several areas. Scientists at Prof Jayashankar Telangana Agricultural University say this could result in an overall decline in crop yields this year.

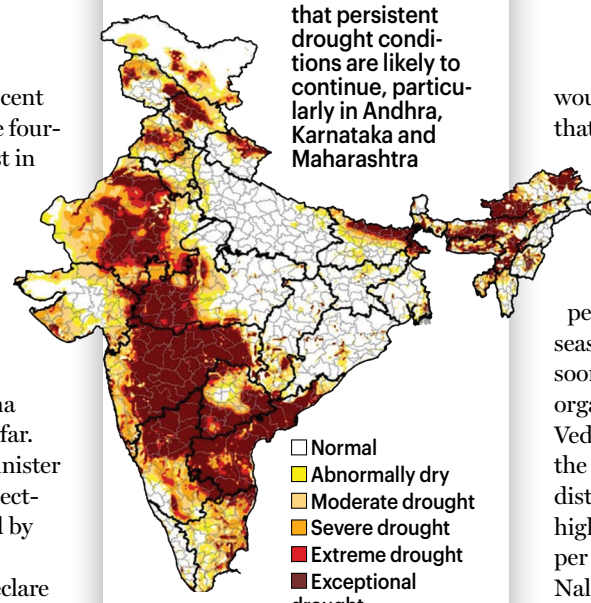
Neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, which witnessed heavy rain in the last week of September, particularly in the north Andhra districts, is staring at drought-like conditions in many mandals. Preliminary estimates indicate an impact of El Niño in 513 mandals, with the situation deemed severe in more than half of them.

A SWINGING MONSOON

Behind the current crisis is a bigger change. Monsoon rains, says Professor Vimal Mishra, dean, research and development, IIT Gandhinagar, now happen in terms of extreme events where the number of rainy days in a season is decreasing and the number of days with extreme heavy rainfall is increasing. The extreme rains cause floods in local regions, usually in smaller areas, but the consequent dry spells causing drought-like conditions normally cover a much larger area. "You may see a lot more drought and floods in the same season, that's where we are heading to, partly because of climate change. As temperatures go up, whenever there is less rain, it causes drought-like situations very quickly," says Mishra.

Since the rainy days are fewer,

A DRY OUTLOOK



Forecasts indicate that persistent drought conditions are likely to continue, particularly in Andhra, Karnataka and Maharashtra

Rootzone (0-100 cm) soil moisture drought category forecasts, predicted: Oct. 5-11 (3 weeks ahead)

Source: Centre for Climate Studies, IIT Bombay

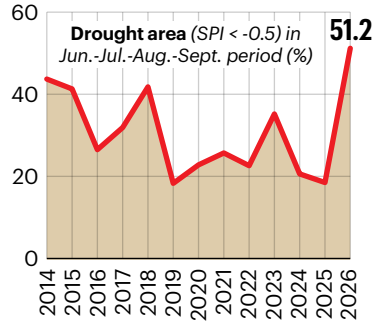
WHAT'S A DROUGHT YEAR?

When the overall rainfall deficit is more than 10% and more than 20% of the area is affected by drought conditions

THE DRYING SPREAD

51.2%

of India's area faced drought in the first nine months of 2026; 18.54% in 2025 and 20.5% in 2024



***SPI:** Standardised Precipitation Index, which quantifies precipitation deficits or surpluses over specific time scales*

***Source:** India Drought Monitor by IIT Gandhinagar's Water and Climate Lab*